



2018 Examiners' Report

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This report highlights the key observations of the Examiners to provide information and help for those who sat the 2018 Masters of Wine Examination as well as guidance for future candidates. The videos of the Exam feedback interviews are published on the Institute's website and candidates are encouraged to watch the recording. It is a valuable addition to this report. Each section has been written by the Panel Chair of the respective panel of Examiners, and draws on the detailed comments made by the individual Examiners assessing the papers.

1. Chief Examiner introduction

John Hoskins MW

The Practical and Theory Reports are full of important feedback that I hope you find useful. The Theory results were again excellent with a pass rate of around 30%. The Practical percentage remains disarmingly low, but we did have 19 people pass the test, over a third of them who were doing it for the first time. It is achievable!

I have just three things to add to what is written by the other examiners below.

1. Software problems with the 2018 exam

The software problems with this year's exam added a lot of unnecessary stress and hassle to many candidates in all 3 exam centres, particularly Australia. The IMW office team, led by Olly Chapman, will make it their absolute priority for the coming year that this does not happen again. We cannot have you, the candidates, disadvantaged by technical problems when you are already facing the enormous pressure of sitting a week of extremely onerous exams, for which you have prepared long and hard.

I can only assure you that we, as the exam team, took that extra stress and hassle into account when looking at your marks this year. All candidates that were anywhere close to a pass on any paper were 'moderated' by the senior exam team after the initial round of marking. Where the 'benefit of the doubt' could be considered, it was certainly given, particularly of course to those who submitted 'mitigating circumstances'.

2. Chances of improvement from a low start

Recently the office has done some statistical analysis of past results and discovered one clear fact. Candidates who score below an average of 45% across their Practical Papers (so that's anyone who got 3 E's, and most who got one D and 2 E's) almost never go on to pass the exam – less than 5% in fact. The same applies with those scoring less than 55% in Theory (three D's).

It is of course possible that you will be the exception to the rule. But looking through this year's papers at the moderation stage it was clear to me that there are a lot of candidates who have got through to the exam stage but are really not in with a chance of passing the exam. My strong and sincerely-intended advice is that if you have had such low scores, do not just push on the following year, most likely wasting both time and money. Take a break and use that break to increase your experience and expertise in all the areas where you know you are weak. The MW Stage 2 is a 'revision' year; you need to go into it with all the content already in place; it's too late otherwise.

I am sure that most people who are on the course (particularly now when admission is so stringent) have the potential to pass the exam. The big question is when. Don't do it if you are not ready. Assess how far off you are and come to the exam when the moment is right for you.

3. Standards of English on type-written Practical papers

Putting aside the technical issues of 2018, a typed paper should present better to the examiners. No issues of poor hand-writing or messy crossings out. In fact the examiners now often breathe a sigh of relief when reaching a hand-written paper. The text is clearly divided into the pre-printed sections; the legibility is not always easy but at least we know that the words are 'as intended'. What we get on type-written scripts can often come over as a kind of 'word-dump', a stream of consciousness response, with notably poor spelling. The problem is that no-one ever has time to check their work in Practical, it's always a struggle to get it done. On the other hand the examiners can only mark what they are given.

So, if typing, please type less and check your work. It will gain you marks, for sure.

2. Practical Panel Chair report

Philip Tuck MW

Introduction

This report should be read in conjunction with previous year's reports and the very comprehensive 'MW Practical Examination Guidelines' that the education team have put together and is available via the MW website.

The number of passes in 2018, whilst slightly up on 2017, was very similar in percentage terms. I would like to reiterate that there is no 'quota' related to the number of students passing this exam. If any candidate is good enough, they will pass. This year 19 candidates reached the required standard and our sincere congratulations goes to all of them for their excellent tasting ability. There were many more who were close but, disappointingly, more than usual who came across as far too inexperienced to be sitting at this stage. Over 10% of candidates failed to average even 40% across all three papers.

This year we were determined to include a large number of top quality examples throughout the three papers. It was good to see that the best candidates clearly enjoyed those wines, despite the pressure and intensity of the exam. It's essential that enthusiasm and a genuine love of great wines comes through in your answers.

General Observations

Having done this job for a number of years now, it's clear that students sitting the MW practical exam tend to make the same kind of mistakes, perhaps unsurprisingly. Sometimes the problem is simply inaccurate tasting, but if the tasting is reasonably good then the mistakes tend to fall into four main areas: timing; assessment of quality; depth of understanding of winemaking techniques; logic of the geographical or varietal conclusion. All these shortcomings can be successfully overcome with consistent and rigorous practice. Candidates must work out which are their weak areas and work intensely on those.

This year's set of papers contained perhaps more examples of 'classic' styles than in the immediate past. I'm pleased that there were many excellent answers to these wines so the message seems to be getting through regarding the need to understand these styles and recognise their quality. However, of those candidates who didn't quite get over the line, it was often their poor assessment of quality that proved their downfall. This was particularly the case for the Côte Rôtie in Paper 2 and the Champagnes in paper 3.

Another common failing this year was the inaccurate assessment of alcohol levels. One examiner made a specific comment related to the Shafer Chardonnay and the Riesling Auslese, where accurate tasting of alcohol was a key to unlock the origin.

As I said last year, the need to practice consistently is vital. Despite the global spread of the student body, I would urge all students to form tasting groups which, while also reducing costs, will enable students to learn from each other. Masters of Wine need to be generalists; it is not good enough to rely on expertise from a limited number of regions. It was clear this year that some students have very little idea about wines from certain regions and this shows in their reasoning. It's also a reason why students often fail to score full marks when they have the correct answer. One candidate, for example, thought the Torrontés came from Bio Bio in Argentina. They did very well to recognise the variety (as did the majority of students) but their knowledge of Argentina let them down. Candidates need to build up comprehensive knowledge of every wine region in order to avoid making these errors.

On the subject of language, which continues to be an area of great concern amongst many of the students I talk to around the world, I would say this: try to use professional language that conveys your thinking as clearly as possible. Imagine that you are talking to a respected, senior member of the trade who you are trying to impress. There was a lot more unprofessional language this year which the examiners did not consider appropriate or set the right tone. For example, qualitative terms such as ‘stonking’ or ‘icon’, do not engender confidence, the latter being an overused marketing term. Similarly, describing a region as ‘Goldilocks’ or for a wine to be targeted to ‘hippies, beatniks and bobos’ reflects poorly on the seriousness of the candidate. One candidate even wrote ‘Much better than merely bulk quality like Yellowtail’...for the Yellowtail Chardonnay! As I have said before, the use of a monetary value to corroborate a specific quality is fine, but it needs to be realistic and make sense. Stating ‘entry level’ is fine, but associating that quality with a value of ‘£30-£40’ even for Champagne, is certainly not.

Whilst there were a few bad spelling mistakes (‘Duoro’, Cortone Charlemagne’, ‘Savanierres’, ‘Rhinegau’) these were not as prevalent as in previous years. Thankfully the use of acronyms has also diminished. Please refer to last year’s report for more detail in this area. However there were the usual host of other theoretical inaccuracies that, whilst not always an absolute disaster individually, can serve to undermine the confidence of your examiner. Here are some extreme examples from this year’s exam, the sorts of statements that are likely to ensure a borderline paper would fail to gain the final few marks to cross the line:

- The suggestion that an LBV Port had had 15 years in wood.
- The suggestion of 2016 as the likely vintage for a (Vintage) Champagne (please note we are talking about the 2018 exam).
- The suggestion that Bandol is in the Southern Rhone.

As I mentioned last year, another key reason why several papers scored C+ rather than B was because they failed to answer questions with sufficient depth. Students need to be very mindful of the number of marks allocated to each element of the question. This comes back to practice and timing. A number of candidates this year might well have passed were it not for a number of blank sections. Well prepared students will always get their timing right, even when confronted with a new style, or wording, of a question. Students should expect and anticipate different or new styles of questions.

Specific Observations

White Wines - Paper 1

Question 1

Very pleasingly, virtually every candidate plumped for Chardonnay here. However, many failed to achieve maximum marks while spending too much time on the first part of the question, writing too much. It is important to practise writing succinctly, whilst mindful of the marks available, especially when answering questions of this style. When it comes to assessing quality in this type of question, it is often helpful to re-taste the first couple of wines to ensure your palate is properly calibrated, particularly at the beginning of the exam. Many candidates over-estimated the quality of both the Yellowtail and the Shafer, failing to address the sweetness of the first and the high alcohol (14.9%) and heavy oak of the second. The Kumeu River Chardonnay was frequently mistaken for good Burgundy which was not a major error – the quality was comparable. I was also pleased that a large number of scripts found Chablis, and good Chablis, for wine 2.

Question 2

The middle flight of wines proved relatively straightforward in terms of varietal recognition (with the understandable exception of the Soave) but many were let down by weak quality assessments and winemaking observations. Candidates must be honest in their search for oak. Many more answers found oak when it wasn't there than vice versa. My previous advice to adopt a chronological approach to the winemaking question seems to have been heard. The Soave was by far the most difficult wine to assess, with the best answers concentrating on the structural elements of the wine and arriving at a logical conclusion that gained good marks, even if wrong. One candidate who did spot its origins correctly needs to be aware that Soave is not a grape variety! The Torrontés was particularly well answered, especially given that, unusually, it was produced with the use of oak.

Question 3

This was another straightforward question that some candidates seemed to want to complicate. Sadly a few didn't spot Riesling correctly – which made it almost impossible to pass this particular question. Although good marks were gained for various origins for Wine 11, relatively few candidates had both wines in Germany, suggesting that they might have been making the error of not judging the wine in the glass, but trying to guess what the examiners had been planning. Accurate assessment of both alcohol and sugar was obviously key here. Please be sure to be specific in your alcohol and sugar assessments rather than writing a range - see the Practical Guidelines.

Red Wines – Paper 2

Question 1

This style of question has appeared before and, on the face of it, was very straightforward for experienced, well prepared students. For such a question the examiners attempt to find wines that are an accurate reflection of origin and we did feel that all the examples showed a clear sense of place. We were therefore disappointed that many missed out on either origin or quality (or both) on these 'classic' wines. The Brunello was often mistaken for Barolo (not a disaster by any means) and was otherwise well answered, as was the Chambolle-Musigny, although the quality here was seriously underestimated. Was the subtlety lost on some of the candidates? The Côte Rôtie, perhaps understandably because of the intensity of this example, was not pinpointed in every case but its quality and sense of place was certainly appreciated by the stronger candidates. Most people found the red Bordeaux to be from the left bank, which in itself was understandable given the tertiary element to the aroma. The Rioja was also quite well answered. However, to pass this question, it was not only important to come close on the geographical origin of the wines and back this up with sound theoretical argument, but also to assess the quality accurately. So there was a lot of work to do on question 1 in order to pass well. Those who did pass this question normally went on to pass the paper and indeed the whole exam. I cannot emphasise enough how essential it is to have a very sound grasp of such wines in order to pass this exam. It was very disappointing that so many candidates clearly cannot recognise the origin and quality of classic wines from Europe. Clearly there is more work to be done here.

Question 2

Thankfully virtually everyone spotted Pinot Noir here. Not to have done so would have meant an inevitable failure in this question. Unfortunately, as I alluded to earlier, Burgundy seemed to find its way into many of the answers, suggesting mind games were at play again. A fundamental discipline with the MW practical exam is to taste the wine in the glass. Winemaking was also fundamental here - the ability to tie the characters of the wine back to the winemaking techniques. Many students overstate the use of specific techniques like 'cold soak'; some elements of winemaking are clear, some are conjectural. Fortunately, the relative qualities of the wines was well understood and the Felton Road was particularly appreciated.

Question 3

Whilst the vast majority of candidates correctly identified Syrah as the grape variety involved here, and scored well as a result, the number who then went on to even consider that they might come from Hawkes Bay, one could count on the fingers of one hand. As I have said before, it is important to approach this exam from a global context as it is our intention to highlight areas of the viticultural world that are emerging, as well as the more established areas. Please do not ignore Hawkes Bay as a source of first rate Syrah, as the Trinity Hill wine admirably illustrates. Section 'B' of this question was particularly important here. Clear and accurate quality assessment was key to doing well in this question where the best students were both confident and enthusiastic about the quality of both wines but the Trinity Hill in particular.

Question 4

Thankfully, the origin of the final pair of wines was answered well. Clear varietal character will have helped in this regard. There was, however, a tendency to default to an area without sufficient backup. The Zinfandel was very well answered, perhaps better than any other wine in the paper although the examiners thought the quality was not as good as many suggested. Conversely, hardly anyone was sufficiently effusive about the quality of wine 12. There was perhaps an indication that just because the origin was correctly identified as Chile, the quality should be downplayed. Taste the wine in isolation first and try not to let your mind play tricks with you. Chile is making world class Cabernet Sauvignon that is also showing a clear sense of place.

Mixed Wines - Paper 3

Question 1

I'm told that there were many students who emerged from Paper 3 with a smile on their faces which is heartening to hear after a long and onerous series of exams. I can't remember having a question where sparkling, sweet and fortified wines are all grouped together, but I'm pleased to say the vast majority of candidates were accurate in the geographical assessments. However, in order to pass this question, an accurate understanding of quality and maturity (as well as sound winemaking knowledge) was essential. Unfortunately this is where many candidates fell down, particularly in relation to discussion on vintage characteristics, both recent and past. One candidate had 2016 as the vintage for one of the Champagnes and another had an alcohol of 10.5% for one of the Sauternes, both of which would render the wine illegal. Little mention was made of the Sauternes being of Cru Classé level and many talked about stainless steel fermentation. In last year's report I said that this is an area that would be looked at again. Some students failed to take the clues from the question. Where a specific question is about the vintage, it is safe to assume the wine is from a specific vintage and from a sufficiently classic area for the vintage characteristics to be well known. The Anderson Valley or England would not come into this category. Yet several students thought one or both the Champagnes were non-vintage and a 10 year old Tawny port was also found. One candidate thought the Champagnes were from the same vintage which seemed a little bizarre given how different they tasted. The best candidates were thorough in their winemaking observations and tied these back to what they could taste in the glass. Everyone knows how these three styles of wine are made, so this was considered a very straightforward exercise. Students need to adopt a technique that allows them to score maximum marks on this type of question. Pleasingly, the quality and maturity element of this question was well addressed but only the best answers gave equal weight to both sections of the question. In short, this question allowed the best candidates to really shine, showing passion for the subject, understanding and authority.

Question 2

As a trio of wines, these were perhaps the worst answered of all the wines in the entire exam, not only from the point of view of potential origin, but also quality, irrespective of the origin. Even when candidates were in France, there were wildly differing origins and quality levels. I accept that the

white Chateauneuf was very challenging and this was taken into account, but the other 2 were classic examples. For the St Romain the quality was often vastly over stated – Chevalier Montrachet, Le Montrachet, Batard Montrachet, Corton Charlemagne etc; the ripeness of the 2015 vintage clearly seduced candidates here. Outside France, there were many good stabs at Australia where candidates could still have garnered enough marks to pass the question, but only with logical reasoning and accurate tasting for the quality and maturity elements of the question. Spain, South Africa and Germany were less plausible.

Question 3

These three wines were answered with a lot more accuracy and logic, despite, in my view, being considerably more challenging. The Bandol in particular was spotted by many candidates and was backed up with correct and accurate analysis. This shows it can be done! Thankfully the clue in the question was well heeded and very few candidates concluded grape varieties that fell outside the Rhone although some of the conclusions were a little implausible – Mourvèdre from Cahors? Tannat from Mendoza (not Cafayate)? Numerous candidates used the same grape variety twice in this question despite the instruction that the three wines were made from different grape varieties. Examiners did wonder if the candidates did not know, or could not think of, three different Rhone varieties. Somewhat predictably, Syrah crept into most answers but this was by no means a disaster. There were many suggestions of Syrah from Hawke's Bay, which was ironic coming after the examples in Paper two.

Conclusion

I am tempted to repeat much of what I wrote in last year's conclusion to this report as it all still holds true. Please heed previous advice. I would also like to emphasise that the examiners do try to take an extremely positive approach. Benefit of the doubt is always given, and we always look to award marks where we can. I am conscious however, that the majority of this report can come across as overly negative, so I assure you that this is only to highlight to most common mistakes, which seem to crop up year after year.

I am convinced that rigorous practice combined with honest feedback is the only route to passing next time. It is in the nature of the exam that there are many pitfalls through all three papers and to fall in any of them can undermine the confidence of the examiner. We are looking for confidence and authority, for answers written convincingly and with consistency. There are no shortcuts.

Finally, I would like to thank my fellow examiners for the huge amount of work they put in when preparing this exam behind the scenes and for giving up a very considerable chunk of their summer to undertake the marking. It is greatly appreciated.

3. Overall Theory Panel Chair Report

Neil Tully MW

This year's theory exam produced 30 full theory passes, representing a 31.25% pass rate (2017 = 32.7%), and two single paper re-sits.

These results demonstrate that a good number of candidates in this year's theory exam came into the exam room with an appropriate level of knowledge and understanding and, importantly, knew how to deploy that knowledge to good effect in response to the questions set. Many of the unsuccessful candidates, whilst perhaps having the necessary knowledge, were unable to use it effectively.

Candidates would be well advised to gauge the level of depth and detail required for a successful response to a question at MW level. Many of the questions set could have been answered in a superficial manner with a basic level of detail, but the MW exam does require a certain precision and insight, of which candidates should be very conscious. In combination with an appropriate level of depth and detail, examiners are also looking for evidence of analytical thought. Very often, simply repeating processes or procedures will not suffice. Equally an overabundance of examples can sometimes mask a lack of fundamental understanding.

Examiners across all theory papers this year commented on the repeated use of a limited number of examples. On theory paper 2, one examiner noted 21 out of 56 papers using the same reference to Domaine Dujac. While it is not unsurprising that material from seminars may be widely cited, it does not indicate a broad frame of reference. While the more commonly used examples may for very good reasons be seen as "go to" examples, examples taken from a candidate's own experience and enquiry, used appropriately, will stand out all the more. However, a word of caution; when using examples over-familiarity, even if those individuals being cited are well-known to the candidate, does not strike a suitable tone: "At Churton in Marlborough, Sam will decide to include stems...", and in another example: "According to Mike, the perceived benefit of inclusion of stems...".

It should be emphasised that those candidates whose first language is not English, and who are not *extremely* comfortable writing in English, should seriously consider writing in their native language.

In summary, candidates looking to elevate their marks would be well advised to consider first whether they are writing with an appropriate level of depth and detail, secondly whether they are showing evidence of critical analysis. This should all be conveyed in a suitable tone, and underpinned with appropriately chosen examples.

3i. Theory Paper One

Joel Butler MW

General Comments

This year's Theory Paper 1 focused on some of the key viticulture issues facing the global wine industry. The Paper also asked candidates to consider current and changing roles for viticultural practices such as pruning and whether or not old vines are worth the trouble on a practical level. Several of the themes, such as pruning and the issue of trunk diseases, were set to test candidates' grasp of real-world technical issues and scientific aspects that vine growers globally must reckon with daily. As has been repeatedly noted, Paper 1 requires a sound knowledge, technical understanding and practical application of that knowledge with appropriate examples in order to pass. Examiners noticed this year a number of papers which cited arguments from specific writers/authorities without, however, noting where the opinion or comment came from.

Question 1: Many wine regions can produce wine at a wide range of price points. Referencing at least two of such regions, compare and contrast methods of managing vineyards for high priced wines and low priced wines.

This question allowed for wide discussion, a multitude of good examples/areas to draw from, and was one that would show a candidate's wide experience and understanding of the global wine world. Unfortunately, this was the least well answered question on Paper 1. A number of responses simply described viticultural practices without actually doing the analyses the question requires. The question required a relatively detailed look at least two regions; some papers provided a scatter-shot of many regions' approaches, but did not address the relative value of these approaches from the question's perspective of addressing high and low value wine production.

Average papers did often show an understanding of what the question was asking about, with good examples, but as one Examiner noted, "there is a lack of in-depth knowledge, facts and figures relating to the costs of viticulture and wine." In other instances, there was clear understanding, but virtually no examples to make the discussion complete, or with generic ones at best. While the question allowed for many issues to be compared and contrasted, the Examiners felt that there were between five and seven that specifically needed to be addressed. It was frustrating, as one Examiner noted, to see much written well about yield vs. quality and price, but then nothing on the implications of harvesting for high vs. low priced wines. Too many papers, sadly, were 'close' but missed because of omitting a key issue at the expense of too much discussion about some of the others.

Passing papers were well organised, with clearly defined comparison of the regions and with good analyses comparing methods used by different estates and different regions. Even here, however, it was often noted that many papers failed to more closely examine the financial implications of some decisions taken.

Question 2: Referencing at least three wine regions, discuss how climate change is influencing grape growers' viticultural practices.

Responses to this question may have been organised by region, or practices; only two did the former! The question required *comparative analyses*, not simply a litany of issues climate change is causing globally. Certainly, it was critical to include discussion of issues such as water and canopy management, disease and pest control, frost/hail pressure, legal aspects resulting from appellation

rules and economic pressures. This question asked for real-world solutions to the challenges across different climates/regions. Some papers only considered warm climates, without an adequate discussion of climate change in cooler ones.

The question required a solid technical understanding of key viticultural practices that would need to change as the climate does. A number of papers showed an understanding and general knowledge about a specific issue, but then failed to note, for example, how important pruning/canopy management practices would need to change in compensation for climate change. This question highlighted for Examiners a significant problem seen across all of Paper 1; factual errors. Where a response shows a clear error, such as placing Katnook Estate in Barossa Valley rather than properly in Coonawarra, it will undermine credibility of the rest of the paper's discussion. Candidates need to write from authority, and given that a question such as this and many others on Paper 1 ask about generally concrete issues, factual errors are inexcusable.

Question 3: Identify the most important trunk diseases in vineyards around the world. How can they be best controlled and managed?

This technically demanding question was answered relatively well, given the precise knowledge required. Critical to success here was answering both parts of this question. Less successful papers did well on identifying the most important trunk diseases, but failed to consider in depth control and management. Key to a successful answer was an acknowledgement of the global reach of these diseases: differences, varieties, treatments. A passing paper *had to include at least three* of the four to five key diseases noted globally. Many papers discussed Esca and Eutypa, but left out Botryosphaeria and Phomopsis. The best papers highlighted diseases affecting younger vines specifically, like Petri disease or black foot disease. A few papers got into long discussions about phylloxera and/or flavesence dorée; these are not trunk diseases! Factual errors, such as claiming that five to seven year old vines are middle-aged, or that GTD's are caused by viruses, not fungi, reflected poorly on candidates' knowledge and weakened their argument significantly.

Examiners noted a strong dependence on one or two particular examples that are indicative of the same 'textbook' source, or an article. Examiners commented that many papers simply didn't do an adequate job of comparing and contrasting various techniques to deal with these diseases depending on location and climate. Positively, the best papers, as one Examiner commented: "Answers the question and answers key points. Good introduction, conclusion and structure. Includes good critical analysis with good comparative examples to support analysis, with a global range. Good writing style—A+"

Question 4: Is the use of cover crops worthwhile in viticulture?

This was the most successfully answered question on this year's Paper 1. Perhaps because the question had a certain "Op-Ed" aspect, requiring a candidate to express an opinion (based upon sound factual examples and knowledge, however), this made for more fluid discussion. In a few papers, however this led to sweeping generalizations, such as "Cover crops are very necessary for viticulture". This question demanded clear understanding of what cover crops do, in different climates, and depending on availability of water. A number of papers, Examiners noted, were overly descriptive, though studded with examples. These generally answered a different question than posed, i.e. What do cover crops do? The question as set was asking for an analysis that looked at cover crops as one component of viticulture, perhaps in relation to climate change, or to the unique challenge of a particular terroir, but also considered the effectiveness of a given approach. It was not enough to list examples of where cover crops are used or not; it was necessary to discuss their utility

in the context of their intended purpose. Advantages and disadvantages needed to be addressed, and examples used to demonstrate where the use of cover crops may be considered 'worthwhile'.

Good candidates used four to six positive or negative reasons, each discussed well. Those that did not focused narrowly on fewer ones such as soaking up excess rainfall in cooler humid areas, or not using them in more arid climates. Good papers noted more nuanced utility; for example, cover crops used to prevent erosion and help with water penetration in the harsh Douro climate. Good answers were attuned to the particular uniqueness of various sites relative to slope, site vigor and frost potential or certification for organic viticulture. It was also useful to consider the economic utility of cover crops, considering the extra cost entailed in planting/cultivating cover crops relative to the wine type and value produced.

Question 5: What is the role of pruning when managing an established vineyard?

This was a question that needed a definition of pruning, **relative** to working in a functioning vineyard. The question was about how pruning a vine affects vineyard growth, quality and economic value and not about describing pruning techniques. A good answer had to define and explain the key purposes of pruning, but always in the context of the question. Smart answers addressed winter pruning, spring/summer pruning (hedging, sucker thinning), and where appropriate, 'green' pruning of less mature clusters to even out maturation or remove deficient fruit (under-ripe, raisined, or rotten berries).

It was critical for a passing paper to address the issue of pruning relative to specific varieties and wine styles, and the timing of pruning and treatments for pruning wounds (at least in passing). Good papers addressed both the advantages and disadvantages of hand-pruning vs. mechanical, especially with regard to the economic costs and style of wine being produced. Too many non-passing papers were "more concerned with the mechanics of pruning than the role it plays", as one Examiner commented.

A passing paper had to deal with the primary purpose of pruning, establishing yield, with comparison and methodology depending on wine style; e.g. short cane pruning with densely planted Pinot noir in Gevrey Chambertin vs. high-trained quadrilateral cordon with low density spacing in the Central Valley of California.

It was clear to Examiners that too many answers lacked understanding of how winter pruning can strongly affect aspects of ventilation, ease of harvest, disease control or frost alleviation as well as yield. More answers addressed these issues from the perspective of summer pruning and/or simple canopy management. Again, this question saw several papers that used generic arguments or examples, without showing more concrete ones that illustrated the writer's real understanding and consideration of the question.

Question 6: Old vines have a mystique to them. What are the practical challenges and solutions to maintaining vineyards of old vines?

The topic of this question is one which fascinates anyone interested in wine, everyone has an opinion about the superiority of old vine wine! But this question was all about the unique viticultural challenges old vines present in order to continue their existence.

It was important to define old vines; Examiners saw everything from 15 to 20 years old as a minimum age, to 60 years. Considering that the average lifespan today globally for vines is in the 20 to 30 year range, a passing paper had to consider old vines in the context of the location being

discussed, and be clear about how this definition is often conditioned by regulations (e.g. the Barossa Charter), the historical nature of a vineyard region, or its modernity. Provided examples were given which accorded with the writer's premise, different definitions for old vines were allowed.

This question required a substantial knowledge about what problems confront older vines; whether these are related to poor vigour, decrease in productivity, susceptibility to disease, especially trunk diseases or pruning wounds. Not addressing these issues and focussing mainly on the potentially higher quality from a subjective belief in old vines making the best wines, without the critical examination dictated by the question, resulted in failure. The issue of 'maintenance' had to be addressed. The economics of maintaining an old vineyard had also to be considered, particularly in light of increasing mechanization in vineyards with lower costs, vs. the expensive manual labour that old vines almost always require. Over-fertilization of old vines, in the hope of keeping them healthier, had to be weighed in relation to soil or rootstock vigour, as this can stress and overtax an old vine's system. Several papers made the mistake of saying that old vines are more susceptible to drought/water stress. As the Examiners noted repeatedly the opposite is true, as evidenced by their longevity under diverse, often harsh conditions, in places like South Africa, Australia, Santorini and elsewhere. A key challenge for maintaining old vineyards is the difficulty/inability to use more mechanization for their care. This was certainly something that a passing paper had to address; a number of papers did not do so, or only with a minor reference. Older vines require more personal, experienced care, which is difficult to mechanise, though not impossible given enough money and knowledge of a vineyard's capacity for a radical change in its make-up.

Answers that focussed on fewer issues relative to the question, but did so thoroughly, generally achieved higher marks than those which tried to throw in as much as possible, without the appropriate depth of knowledge or examples to support the argument.

3ii. Theory Exam Paper Two

Meg Brodtmann MW

General Comments

Many of the general comments in this year's Examiners' Report are similar to those in previous years. Students would be well advised to consider carefully the winemaking processes for all wine styles and how various decisions and processes affect the outcome of the wine. A successful approach to this paper addresses the whys and wherefores rather than just giving a list of winemaking techniques. Knowledge in and of itself is not enough. We need candidates to *apply* that knowledge. Read the question and then answer it. If the words 'advantages and disadvantages' are in the question they need to be addressed and discussed. Do not tell us everything you know about a topic.

Poor handwriting and spelling was also commented on by examiners. If English is your second language, please consider writing in your native tongue and having the paper translated. If your handwriting is poor, type.

Question 1: Examine the advantages and disadvantages of deliberate stem inclusion, or additions, during the winemaking process.

Candidates who did well focussed on the question at hand – the *advantages* and *disadvantages* of deliberate stem inclusion across all wine styles and the *whole* winemaking process. Too many candidates just gave us a list of who is doing what with stems. Examples should be used to support an argument, not be the argument themselves.

We expected candidates to cover the entire winemaking process, within the scope of Paper 2, not just fermentation. We also expected students to cover white, rosé and red table winemaking as well as mentioning sparkling and fortified wines. Students needed to demonstrate an understanding of why and how stems are used in the winemaking process and then discuss the advantages and disadvantages of their inclusion.

Candidates are reminded to think about winemaking as a process and to consider where stem inclusion may be warranted and what the outcome of that would be – both advantageous and disadvantageous. Students tended to disregard stems within white wines with alarming regularity. Given the amount of natural wines, qvevri style wines, etc, more could have been discussed.

Whilst the argument for stems was often good, the argument against the use of stems was often lacking. Given most wines are destemmed, this could have been argued better. Advantages for stems tend to be concentrated in the three varieties: Grenache, Syrah and Pinot Noir. Given comparisons were needed, varieties like Cabernet Sauvignon or Merlot could have been cited as varieties that may be less appropriate for stem inclusion.

Question 2: Compare and contrast winemaking techniques for 'high end' and 'entry level' Chardonnay in at least two regions.

It is important that students address the question at hand. Terms like 'compare and contrast' are put in to the question for a reason. It is unlikely we will ever ask 'tell us everything you know about winemaking for high end and entry level Chardonnay'. We want to see the ability to filter information and apply that knowledge. This is something we repeat every year in the examiners' report. Critical thinking and application of knowledge are key.

Again, a logical run through of the winemaking process would have helped students and allowed them the ability to compare and contrast the styles and regions. Unfortunately, there was a lack of depth in many cases and a lack of contrast and comparison. Sadly, the examiners' comments were a constant refrain of 'a winemaking list', 'failed to compare and contrast', 'shows lack of depth'.

In these open-ended questions, it is important for students to plan, as we saw many scripts with irrelevant information. This is time and energy wasted in an exam situation. This question allowed candidates to cover the entire winemaking process, but few did.

The key understanding was that the identification of tangible differences in winemaking practices between what is considered high and low entry Chardonnay. The ability to define 'high end' and 'entry level' was also key.

Question 3: Write concise notes on four of the following:

- **Lysozyme**
- **Mannoprotein**
- **CMC – carboxymethyl cellulose**
- **Copper sulphate**
- **Ascorbic acid**
- **YAN – yeast assimilable nitrogen**

Few candidates attempted this question but those that had technical depth did well. Most candidates who failed were missing basic technical detail, for example dosing and legal limits, which are easily obtainable, and seemed unable to structure an accurate short answer.

We expect technical detail in these answers with accuracy in terminology and meaning, along with consideration of the effects of practices/additions. Dose rates and legal limits should be mentioned. Examples can be used to support the statements. The answers to these questions do not have to be long – in fact, a concise response covering off the major points is all that is required. Candidates who did not do well with this question tended to waffle and did not provide enough technical detail.

These types of questions do not follow the essay format which means no introduction or conclusion is required. A few students wasted valuable time on these.

Question 4: What are the critical winemaking considerations for a producer of inexpensive, off-dry still white wines?

This question was answered by many candidates, but few passed. This is a question about commercial winemaking in the real world. Successful candidates focussed on the various options for achieving an off-dry wine style.

Candidates needed to define inexpensive (using local or international currency) and off-dry. Legal limits set by the OIV should have been mentioned to support the argument. Sugar levels could be defined in terms of perception, but it was important candidates demonstrated an understanding of the legal definition of off-dry.

This was another question covering the whole winemaking process. Candidates should have covered fruit ripeness, sugar concentration options in the winery, absolute need for hygiene, options for stopping fermentation, options for adding back sweetness and additions to prevent refermentation. Examples should only be used to support the argument, not be the argument

themselves. Sterile filtration at bottling could have been mentioned but candidates who failed to do so were not penalised.

Students are reminded to be polite – inexpensive does not equal poor quality. Many students were derisive of these wine styles. This acts as a reminder to students that they need to cover ALL wine styles in their studies – not just focus on premium wine production.

This was a technical paper and lack of technical understanding was displayed in many responses. We are looking for critical thinking and application of knowledge. Examiners comments reflected this.

Question 5: Which winemaking decisions affect the ageing potential of a finished wine?

This was another popular question which was focussed on the processes and choices made during winemaking and post-fermentation maturation. The candidate needed to provide a sensible definition of the scope of winemaking – some limited consideration of the vineyard processes was allowed but the primary focus should have been on the vinification process. Ageing potential needed to be defined, finished wine needed to be defined. Examples, as always, needed to be supportive of arguments. One examiner asked: “How do some candidates think a list of examples is enough to pass?”

Students should have discussed why a particular process affects the ageing potential of a wine. As always, still wine, sparkling and fortified wine should have been discussed, as well as entry level through to ultra-premium wines. Too many candidates focussed solely on the premium end of the market and neglected entry level wines. Interestingly, too many candidates only discussed red wines.

There should have been plenty of scope for candidates to provide meaningful examples of what certain winemakers choose to do, why, and the impact on ageing potential. Lack of essay structure, no definition, limited scope and failure to discuss the “whys and wherefores” were the most common errors.

We also urge students that, if they quote a well-known wine or region, they must spell it correctly.

Question 6: How and to what extent can a winemaker influence the textural profile of a wine?

This question required candidates to define textural profile and the scope of the essay. Some viticulture could have been covered but the focus should have been on winemaking, on practices during vinification and maturation that influence the textural profile of the wine.

As there was a great range of topics that could be considered, the responses needed to be well-structured, precise and concise. This was where most candidates failed. Too many responses were just a winemaking list, covering only one or two wine styles without explaining why a particular process would influence wine texture. Again, candidates are advised to think about the entire winemaking process and think about which of the processes may influence texture. As always, examples should be used to support the argument, not be the argument themselves.

Quite a few candidates focussed on a particular wine style without giving thought to all wine styles. We were looking for information on still, fortified and sparkling wine. It was interesting to note a particular focus on red wines. Again, a proper definition of texture would have opened up the scope of the essay to the students.

3iii. Theory Exam Paper Three

Caroline Gilby MW

General Observations

Paper 3 had a relatively high pass rate of close to 50% in 2018, which demonstrates that candidates who have appropriate technical knowledge, supported by real world evidence and examples, can do well.

One complaint from examiners was that many candidates were too simplistic in their answers, giving WSET-type descriptive answers and not explaining "how" or "why" nor showing any analysis. Good candidates used lots of examples and quotes from industry leaders. They worked through a logical list of the risks and benefits and demonstrated analysis of the points they were making, comparing and contrasting, and discussing.

As in previous years, failure to answer the question was a common complaint by examiners. Many candidates failed to answer at least part of the question as set and were tempted into simply writing what they knew about a topic. Lack of numbers and real world practical detail or examples was another common criticism. It has been said before, but it is worth repeating, that a good introduction should summarise understanding of the question and ground to be covered, as this will help candidates focus and would have improved answers in many cases. Another comment from examiners related to the narrowness of examples – perhaps gleaned from course days, rather than independent research?

Paper 3 is a technical paper and it is expected that candidates will have a firm grasp of some key factual and numerical information. EU limits for SO₂ use, being clear about the whether numbers refer to total or free SO₂; typical levels of free SO₂ for various styles; actual values for pH; permitted and actual usage levels for common wine additives; pore sizes for filtration and so on are key knowledge for MWs. Vague comments like "lower levels of SO₂" are not sufficient – actual numbers are required. Inaccurate use of "sulphur" instead of sulphites or sulphur dioxide still crops up regularly, and while this may be widespread short hand among winemakers, there are important differences between sulphur as an element and its compounds.

In summary, candidates who did not pass wrote superficial answers that were descriptive rather than analytical, lacked examples and numbers, or failed to answer the question. Errors of fact were a problem in a number of cases as were candidates who wrote well but simply described what they knew about a topic.

Question 1: How does a laboratory analysis of a wine help the quality control manager make decisions at bottling?

Key understanding

To ensure that the wine reaches the consumer in a state which is palatable, typical and stable; free from faults and contaminants; and compliant with all relevant legislation and regulation. Bottling is a key step in ensuring this and is the last opportunity to make adjustments. Lab analysis is a tool that provides relevant technical information to allow appropriate decisions about treatments and handling (candidates should show an understanding of what these might be - to cover final filtration, additives, microbial stability, hazes, why and what action might be taken).

A number of candidates lacked focus or simply missed too many key issues. Candidates needed to consider both quality checks on wine and checks on the packaging process and dry goods, as well as

compliance with product specification. Too many candidates simply described the bottling process and failed to consider the quality control part of the question and showed lack of awareness of key QC analyses for wine and why they are carried out. Consideration of HACCP and critical control points is always useful in a question that mentions bottling. Quality control is part of the overall quality assurance process, and wine is a foodstuff which must comply with legislative and regulatory standards (so an awareness of EU legislation and ISO requirements is helpful). A lot of candidates missed the critical “why” part which is implied in the question, and without considering this, their answers were too superficial and lacked any analytical depth. The safety of staff handling the liquid and the packaging is also critical (with risks such as broken glass, noise, heavy lifting and exposure to health risks). Issues for the wine itself include loss of quality, consumer disappointment, damage to brand, and costs attached to issuing recalls or being unable to sell the wine.

2. Question 2: each option?

Key understanding

For the movement of bulk wine, two systems are available – ISO tanks and Flexitanks.

ISO tanks: stainless steel vessels designed to fit directly onto standard trucks and also transferred to be transported by rail or sea. They can be constructed as one large tank or divided up into 3 or 4 sectional tanks.

Flexitanks: flexible bags that are fitted into a standard 20ft container. Usually used once only. The latest systems are constructed of polyethylene with a barrier material of ethylene vinyl alcohol (EVOH) copolymer, creating an effective barrier to oxygen and to organic materials that can taint wine.

Given that this is currently such a hot topic for the wine industry it was surprising how many candidates did not have a basic understanding of the options and muddled up ISO tanks and flexitanks. Several candidates misunderstood or misinterpreted the question. They failed to define the key words in the question and therefore went "off piste" from the start. Interpretation of the phrase "bulk wine" should not have been difficult even for non-mother tongue English speakers. The inclusion of paragraphs on bottled wine in several answers gained no points and wasted time. Another issue was candidates writing generalised and descriptive answers around the topic of bulk transport without specifically analysing each option. It is particularly frustrating to see candidates who clearly knew a lot about bulk transport failing because they simply did not address the question.

Good candidates used lots of examples and quotes from industry leaders. They worked through a logical list of the risks and benefits and demonstrated analysis of the points they were making, comparing and contrasting and discussing.

Question 3: What technical factors influence the choice of a closure for wine bottles?

Key understanding

A closure should:

- *Seal the bottle effectively.*
- *Allow fairly easy removal.*
- *Allow sufficient oxygen to migrate into the wine for optimal wine maturation.*
- *Prevent excessive oxygen migration which will cause oxidation.*
- *Not impart foreign flavours to the wine.*

Wine style, shelf life and intended ageing should be considered, but not marketing or image. Mention may also be made of availability of specialist bottling equipment

This was a popular question choice and candidates may also have thought this was an easy question. It should have been a relatively straightforward question to answer but candidates who did not do well often discussed issues around closure choice rather than considering technical factors.

The best essays flowed and read well, covered the key points and supported the argument with facts and examples. A lack of examples was one of the bigger issues for those that failed. Candidates must apply the correct values, rates, measurements, etc. in relation to technical points. This is a key requirement in proving that they have total understanding of what they are discussing.

A considerable number of the essays merely made points without getting into any depth or giving sufficient detail to show to the examiner that they understood not just the question but the point that they were making. As a result a number of the essays rambled when they needed to be more succinct and to the point.

Those essays that just failed to get a pass but came close, often presented some of the key points but tended to leave a reasonable number out. Leaving out a few points can be accepted if coverage and analysis is otherwise sufficient, but too many suggests an overall lack of real understanding.

Question 4: Detail the advantages and disadvantages of the following methods of clarifying a wine:

- a. Earth filtration
- b. Pad filtration
- c. Membrane filtration
- d. Crossflow filtration

Key understanding (across all 4)

Define clarification and explain its role in winemaking process. Show why filtration is used rather than simply settling, especially for large volume production. Address potential for loss of quality and thus importance of choosing optimal filtration method for the wine style and its quality, possibly involving decision not to filter. Data and examples to be provided. Candidates may consider depth filtration methods (a & b) as well as absolute filters (c & d) together.

This was a technical question that required thorough knowledge of the advantages and disadvantages of clarifying a wine. A number of candidates just launched into the advantages and disadvantages of each of the four methods without providing a definition on clarification nor explaining its role in the winemaking process. Even a question in parts like this needs an introduction and definitions. Some candidates interpreted the question as a request to give “notes on” rather than provide a concise discussion of each technical process and its advantages and disadvantages.

Many candidates also didn’t include examples to support the argument. Relevant examples are so important in helping the marker confirm that the candidate understands the point being made. Strong practical examples can help cover/support those candidates whose answers are perhaps ‘marginal’ in terms of technical knowledge.

If a candidate is going to attempt a question that requires discussion of a number of areas, in this case 4 different methods, they should only do so if they feel they can answer adequately at least ¾ of the question. Too many candidates would answer one section well, but the remaining sections were weak.

Good answers provided specific technical and numerical detail such as using correct technical terminology and pore sizes. Less successful responses showed a lack of real understanding and knowledge, being unclear about the different clarification methods - in particular, membrane filtration. Undoubtedly some candidates were running out of time by this stage which may account for limited answers in the latter half of the question.

3iv. Theory Paper Four

Simon Thorpe MW

Question 1: What have been the most important changes in global wine supply and demand in the past three years and what are their implications?

A Paper 4 question which tests all the key criteria for a successful answer. Firstly, it must have accurate data – simple enough to research and replicate. Secondly it must have an international reach in terms of the examples and thirdly it is quite a broad subject and therefore requires a good structure to convey a thoughtful and cohesive argument. Finally, this is a two-part question and it is necessary to allocate equal time and energy to both parts. Therefore a successful answer is one that covers all the above requirements and a less successful answer is one which falls down on one or more of the requirements.

A good number of candidates attempted this question, but there were very few excellent answers. The most common shortcoming was in a lack of analysis of the implications of the changes in demand – the “so what” which is where an MW candidate can really stand out. Also, perhaps due to pressure, there were a great deal of data inaccuracies.

Question 2: What are the advantages and disadvantages of private-label wines for wineries, distributors and retailers?

The structure of the answer here is strongly suggested by the question, so effectively this could have been answered in six paragraphs plus an introduction and conclusion. It is imperative to define what is understood by the term “private-label” and there was quite some confusion around this. Again, the argument requires global knowledge of the supply chain and routes to market and it was felt that there was a great deal of purely superficial knowledge in this regard. This question may have been relatively straightforward for those who work in more commercial roles in the industry but a lot more difficult for those who do not.

Examples tended to relate to one or two geographies, however it is important to demonstrate a broader knowledge. Equally, the examples need to be accurate – an examiner’s faith in the candidate is quickly lost by inaccurate or fabricated answers.

There were a few excellent answers on this question. It is perhaps interesting to note that the really good answers were those which delivered some insight and analysis as well as the bare requirements as set out in the question. Overall though this was not well answered due to a lack of authenticity or credibility in a lot of the writing.

Question 3: How important are environmental credentials in marketing wine?

To quote from the examiners’ indicative answer: *The key point for candidates to recognise is that this is a marketing question, asking them to assess the importance of environmental credentials, not just to list them. They should examine and evaluate every aspect of a winery’s environmental footprint (vineyard practices, use of energy, container used, closure used, transportation to market), and discuss to what extent this affects consumers’ buying behaviour.*

This is not a winemaking or viticultural question, it’s about marketing. It is also a question which requires an opinion, and argument – there is no right or wrong viewpoint, but it is difficult to argue against the growing consumer demand for wines with environmentally friendly credentials.

A clear structure needed to be provided to this question – answering from the viewpoint of the marketer could be quite successful, but it is no good simply listing ways in which wine can exhibit environmental friendliness if that isn't then related to what the consumer feels about it. Geographical variations in demand from a market perspective was vital, especially where it was possible to give empirical evidence to support the point (such as the high and growing percentage of Scandinavian tenders which stipulate organic).

There were a handful of excellent answers; those that provided clarity of thought process, good and interesting examples, relevant links between credentials and propensity to increase spend, consumer acceptance or demand for environmentally friendly wines and an understanding of how wine sits in the context of other food categories. In general, the main areas of challenge for candidates lay in not addressing the marketing nature of the question, and in delivering sweeping statements not backed up by factual evidence.

Question 4: Where are direct to consumer wine sales increasing and why?

This is an uncomplicated question both in terms of subject and structure. However, there was some confusion over the definition of "direct to consumer". It was also not enough simply to "know the theory" - there was a definite requirement for market data in relation to the costs and benefits of direct to consumer sales.

Essentially this was a question where simply ticking the boxes would likely lead to a narrow fail, while those who performed above this level were able to demonstrate an intimate knowledge of some original examples of wineries undertaking the direct to consumer model, also understanding and illustrating the constraints and costs which might lead away from the model.

Question 5: There has been a great deal of innovation in packaging design and formats in other alcoholic beverage categories. Why has the wine industry been slow to follow suit? Should it follow?

Quite a popular question which asked for an opinion and tested the candidates' ability to structure an argument and make a case. On the whole the challenge was taken up and this was well answered with some really good and erudite essays.

There is no right or wrong answer to this question and candidates should feel comfortable that the examiners did not penalise anyone if they disagreed – in fact there was a range of different opinions which were successful. It is the argument and supporting examples which were important here.

The examiners did feel that most time should have been spent on the "Should it follow" part of the question and what they certainly didn't want was simply a list of different packaging designs and formats. In general, this was well answered and allowed candidates to demonstrate some original thinking.

Question 6: Evaluate the extent to which scarcity/rarity is a positive attribute in wine marketing.

A question which many candidates found challenging with a lot of answers way off the mark. Perhaps the somewhat unusual structure of the question "examine the extent to which" put candidates off, but in effect it only means "how much".

The subject matter was relatively narrow, which meant that a good understanding of the key points was essential, as was the need to deploy critical thinking skill. Which examples are best? We are

really exploring both perceived and real scarcity – so how can this be managed? Is there a consumer benefit to scarcity? What are the downsides to scarcity? it's important to look beyond just price as a benefit to both producer and customer.

Too many candidates couldn't demonstrate sufficient detailed knowledge on amounts of wine produced in the classic "icon" wines. In the opinion of the examiners, if you are short of detailed information and examples on a subject then best to avoid it. It was surprising that so many candidates (48) undertook this question and only a very small number passed.

3v. Theory Paper Five

Beverley Blanning MW

General comments

The standard of essay writing improves every year and there are fewer answers which are completely out of line. The difference between a pass and a fail is less clear cut than it has been in the past. While there is a clear minimum standard for a pass, often there isn't anything specific that gets a candidate over the line. It is more a question of authoritative insight, clear communication of ideas and a balanced, convincing argument that elevate an answer to MW standard.

Advice to candidates when approaching this exam:

- Answer the question set, not the question you wish had been set;
- Think as broadly as possible and consider the wording of the question carefully;
- Avoid using the first person, singular or plural;
- Avoid using headings;
- Don't be afraid to challenge conventional wisdom (but always back up your arguments with facts);
- Always put both sides of an argument;
- Reference key facts, especially those that sound unlikely;
- Spell correctly the names of people and wines in your examples. You are the one who chose to use them;
- Paper 5 is not the same as Paper 4. A broader approach is needed.

Question 1: Can wine be considered a social good?

We were looking for a clear definition of a social good from the outset as being something that benefits society as a whole (it might have been helpful to cite examples of social goods, such as clean air, healthcare, literacy, and so on). Many candidates stumbled at this first hurdle: either they failed to define the term, or their essays showed that they had not grasped the meaning of the question. This led to simplistic answers with the inevitable conclusion that wine is 'a good thing', which is not what we were asking.

It is always advisable to consider both sides of the question, in other words, the arguments for and against. Arguments that might support the idea of wine being a social good might include: its cultural, religious and historical importance; it supports small agricultural economies; it facilitates social cohesion and well-being; it generates tax income; it has certain associations with longevity and good health. Arguments against could include: social and health problems; religious objections; legislation and taxation; costs to society.

Many answers were superficial, limited in scope, one-sided and lacking in examples. There was a lot of content about responsible drinking, which is not really relevant to this question. The examiners noted that some candidates persist in giving wine special status within the alcohol sector, implying that wine drinkers are never binge drinkers nor alcoholics. Such a line of argument would require strong supporting evidence to be taken seriously. This was a question that invited examination of the many contentious issues surrounding wine. It was remarkable that, while the answer to the question would undoubtedly be a firm 'no' from many (if not most) in society, hardly any candidates considered this possibility, with 21 of the 24 answers concluding that wine was a social good.

Question 2: How can the wine industry attract new consumers?

This question was set in the hope of eliciting original thought and innovative ideas from the candidates. It was a straightforward and popular question, but the examiners reported few good answers and the pass rate was quite low. What happened? Perhaps the single biggest mistake was candidates' failure to distinguish between new consumers and existing consumers. Some essays were entirely based on how to increase sales among existing consumers. Others wrote solely of Millennials, ignoring every other type of potential new consumer. 'New' is not necessarily 'young'. Equally, when discussing 'the wine industry', candidates needed to break this down into producers, retailers, importers, opinion leaders, and so on.

Successful answers showed understanding of current global wine consumption patterns and identified different strategies that could be adopted for different potential consumers and different markets. It must be stressed that this is not a paper 4 question, so the scope of enquiry was expected to be wider. Candidates could have looked at learnings from recent successes in attracting new consumers, or from other markets. They could have discussed the challenges of attracting new consumers, such as the complexity of the product, taste prejudices, cultural, religious, generational perceptions, presence of competing products, etc. At the same time, it is important in a question like this to present one's own ideas, and not just regurgitate what is happening right now. We expect candidates to show they have an informed point of view and innovative ideas are always welcome.

3. If a global wine disease were destroying all known grape varieties and you had the chance to preserve only two varieties – one white and one black – for humanity, which would you choose to save, and why?

This appeared to be regarded as a fun and easy question, and unfortunately the approach taken by many reflected this. There were some flippant answers that lacked precision and depth. Candidates needed to explain the criteria for their choices – economic, general popularity, viticultural and vinification characteristics, disease resistance, adaptability to different climates and soils, the longevity and quality of the wines, and so on. Many answers failed to do this and simply chose personal favourites. From this narrow starting point, it was an uphill struggle for them to achieve sufficient marks for a pass when so much that could have been said was missing. We were asking candidates to choose wines for humanity, not for themselves, so we were looking for a clear consideration of what was most essential to preserve for others.

There were, however, some very interesting and original essays, where candidates demonstrated their passion, but also their wide knowledge of the complex world of wine. This was a wide-ranging question, with scope for the best candidates to shine. Stronger answers compared and contrasted different potential choices and were balanced in taking a broad, global view and considering the impacts for various parts of the quality/price spectrum. They gave relevant and diverse supporting examples and equal weight to each of the varieties chosen. Arguments for classic varieties were almost always stronger than those for more unusual ones, as they have proven styles, history, global plantings, consumer popularity, etc. Some candidates spent too much time on florid descriptions of wines at the expense of making a persuasive argument.

4. Is elitism an inherent problem in the world of wine?

This was not a popular question, but most of those who chose to tackle it did well. Critical to success was understanding the meaning of elitism. This proved problematic for some, who confused elitism with inequality and even sexism.

If correctly defined, there were many avenues to be explored to address whether elitism is an inherent problem in wine. An historical perspective was needed, with comparison to present day attitudes. Whether or not elitism is considered an inherent problem requires candidates to examine whether this is a perceived problem somehow related to wine more than other goods, so reference to other markets would have been helpful also.

Other areas that could have been addressed include: actual or perceived elitism; wine classification systems; the role of wine qualifications; sales channels and changes in the way wine is bought and sold; whether elitism is a problem, or a positive in some markets or circles; who suffers from elitism and who benefits?

5. Do wine consumers need wine experts?

This was another popular question. Sadly, it was poorly answered by most candidates. The question needed a really clear and broad definition of 'experts', including media commentators, auctioneers, MWs, buyers, retailers, winemakers, consultants, educators etc, and understanding of the varying and different types of wine expertise. A large number of candidates restricted their definition to journalists and therefore gave very incomplete answers. Most also missed the opportunity to talk about the importance of experts involved in the production of wine, which was a significant omission.

Also important was to distinguish between different types of wine consumer, as there will be different requirements of expertise for different types of consumer (generational, geographical, socio-economic, education level, etc).

As always, we were looking for a global perspective, and for candidates to demonstrate an understanding of the dynamic nature of how and why consumers might need wine experts. An appreciation of the changing perception of experts and the rise in importance of peer reviews was also an area to explore.